

Skills required – the telecom experts speak

"To start, the freshers should have foundational competency skills like proficiency in at least one programming language, basic understanding of embedded systems, operating system and software testing. When they start at Sasken, these all are the areas they are trained before starting any domain training/hands-on." —**George Abraham, head-talent acquisition, Sasken Communication Technologies**

"A good understanding of telecom fundamentals, networking basics and programming is essential for development jobs. For customer support or sales, a good understanding of telecom fundamentals and networking basics is essential. In addition, it is very important to have excellent soft skills such as communication (both verbal and written), inter-personnel skills, ability to work under pressure, multi-tasking and quick learning." —**Venugopal Sharma, senior manager, software development, Cisco**

"The skills should match a systems software engineer's profile. For products which are on protocol stacks, C/C++ programming language is widely used. For manageability products, Java is the preferred language. Other skills include thorough knowledge of data structures, design patterns, systems analysis and design, problem solving and analytical abilities." —**Janardan Revuru, project manager, Hewlett Packard**

"Fundamentally, they should be strong in all the subjects they have studied during their graduation level. Apart from this, they should possess strong IQ, EQ, logical and analytical capabilities, understanding of the OOP's concepts and basic database concepts, good communication skills, good aptitude and positive attitude. Also, they should be good at numeric abilities and should be a good team player." —**Arshad Majeed, executive vice president, service delivery, Xavient**

the industry prospects bright," says Khan.

Telecom—a top sector

Telecom, being one of the fastest growing sectors, there is a great demand for skilled and qualified aspirants with a good technical know-how.

Broadly classifying the telecom sector into two categories of companies, Venugopal Sharma, senior manager, software development, Cisco, says, "Basically, there are companies that provide telecom services, such as carriers like Airtel and Reliance, and companies that develop products for the telecom sector, such as Cisco, Alcatel Lucent and Juniper to name a few."

Sharma adds, "This industry has seen a significant growth in the recent years, primarily due to high penetration of mobile and hand-held devices and the services that run on them. The industry certainly has huge potential."

In India, the telecommunication industry is poised for growth. With the advent of higher-bandwidth technology, there will be growth in applications that require that bandwidth and devices that can utilise that bandwidth.

Sridhar Parthasarathy, vice-pres-

ident, telecom business unit, Maveric Systems, believes, "The industry is at an inflection point preceding an explosive growth. This would also enable carriers to offer differentiating higher-end services and improve their average revenue per user."

Immense scope

The telecommunications industry comprises numerous areas and hence there are various kinds of jobs in the industry.

Arshad Majeed, executive vice-president, service delivery, Xavient, says, "Many jobs are related to the development and maintenance of devices, lines, systems and networks used to facilitate communication. This offers a wide range of career prospects, and one can have a career in application/product development, application testing, ERP implementation/integration, system administration, network planning, data networking, mobile application development and value-added services."

Telecom providers are tapping the potential of services that are rendered on mobile and connected devices (like TV and Internet).

Sharma says, "These companies

require large capex and skilled manpower for their expansion to host and provide these services. With this growth, telecom product developers (that develop devices that are the building blocks of these networks) need to churn out newer products, with intelligent features and services."

Talking about the telecom sector from the enterprise perspective, "There will always be migration of matured products to low-cost geographies (like India). And the expectation from Indian divisions to extract 'innovation' out of it will continue for the next decade," says Revuru.

Talking about the consumer side, he says, "Indians will continue to be app-savvy and gadget freaks. With sustained buying power of consumers, more start-ups will emerge with innovative solutions. Watch out for a promising start-up and get your foot into the industry."

Telecom—a complex field

Talking about telecom's inherent complexity, Sridhar Parthasarathy says, "It takes an intricate ballet of the physical network, software, analytics, regulatory framework and value-added services to help you connect that call within microseconds of dialling the digits."

"If you think about it, it is just so astounding that in that half second between hitting the call button, the software figures out what ringtone the called party has set and plays it to you, even if she is at the other end of the world!"

This complexity requires multiple people with varied skills to come together and work. There is definitely enough scope at all levels for the qualified and the challenge seekers.

High priority to computer, IT and electronics engineers

"Product companies largely look for engineering graduates (having computers, electronics or communications background) since most of the work involves research and development," says Sharma.